Letters to a Distant Future

By Ian Del Tredici

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents either are products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual events , locales or persons, living or dead, is entirely coincidental.

Foreword

The following entries were taken from the diary of a now deceased man with his full consent and willingness. They depict the life of a boy, son, and human during the turmoil of the great climate crisis of the 21st century. Posthumously titled "Letters to a Distant Future", *this selected collection is intended to provide a glimpse into the past, detailing the lives of those most affected by the circumstances of their time. It is a recording of a deep, cutting injustice, one whose wounds inflicted will never truly heal. The kind of amoral activity we hope to condemn and destroy with the actions we take today. The names and identifying information of the characters throughout these essays have been removed for their privacy and ours. All those described in this story are representative of thousands, if not millions, more just like them. The pain of injustice is never felt alone. Let these memories serve as a reminder and memorial for all those lost, slighted, or harmed by the climate crisis and its surrounding violence. May their stories live on through his.*
- Editor

Dedicated to all those who rebel against injustice.

Letters to a Distant Future

January 26, 2025

Around the time I stopped receiving toys for presents and instead experienced the unbridled joy of unwrapping boxes of clothing and school supplies, Mom gave me this journal for my birthday. That was a few years ago. I had never expressed any interest in distilling my thoughts onto paper but I suppose she thought I had enough socks to last me another year. When I opened it she explained I might enjoy the literal practice of writing my own story and that it might be nice to have something to look back on in the future. Something about telling the stories of injustice too. I'm not sure what she means by that but I've decided to jot down some thoughts just to please her. I don't really know what to write about yet but she said that I'll know when I know.

Anyway here's 10 things I know right now:

1. The year is 2025.
2. I am 15 years old.
3. I am in 10th grade.
4. I like reading science fiction.
5. The birthday before this journal Mom got me a remote control car and a LEGO set.
6. I live with my parents, Mom and Dad, and my younger brother.
7. When I was seven I got in trouble for breaking a picture of Grandma and Grandpa. It was a nice picture too, clearly taken by a professional and set in a gold frame. The thing is, I didn't even break it. My brother, who was 5 at the time, knocked it over as he was running to his room in a fit, probably because we ran out of grape juice or something. But from where I was standing I saw the picture wobble and fall as he knocked the shelf with his hip. I ran to catch it but I was too late. The picture crashed to the ground, the frame splintering and shards of glass leaping out. I didn't know what to do so I went to get help but when I told Mom she thought I had knocked it over and wouldn't even listen when I told her it wasn't me. It was so unfair. I had to pay for it to be replaced too.
8. Outside, if you walk past all the houses to the end of the street, there's a big tree with a swing on it. I broke my arm there once. I don't remember much except that it hurt real bad. There was nobody to help me so I just walked back to the house. When I came inside my mom saw me holding my arm and screamed. She says that I wasn't even crying or anything.
9. Ever since I can remember Dad has worked at the power plant nearby. The big gray one, with the letters NEXO on it and five or six smokestacks shooting up. Every morning he leaves before I wake up and he comes home after the sun is down. Often I can tell when he's home just by the smell when he opens the door. I used to wrinkle my

nose when he walked in but I’ve gotten used to it over the years. Even now when I ride past the flimsy metal fence outside the plant I still get a kind of nostalgia and comfort. Dad doesn’t love the job but he says it pays the bill and it's the reason I can play Mario Kart.

10. I love Mario Kart.

October 6, 2025

We started learning about the climate crisis today in class. On Monday we looked at the causes and effects of greenhouse gases, particularly carbon dioxide and methane. Our teacher put on an old video about how the molecules rise up into the air and form a kind of blanket over our heads. It was somewhat comforting to me, to know we're all bundled up together beneath this thing. But I know this blanket is causing a whole host of problems so I try not to get too caught up in my cozy fantasy.

We learned about the history of climate change too. How it started and all the sorts of things we've done to try to stop it. It's almost embarrassing that we've known about this since the 1970s but we still haven't done anything about it. I mean how hard could it be to just suck up all the pollution out of the air.

It reminds me of when I accidentally spilled a whole can of paint in the garage. I think I jostled it while searching for my old baseball bat or something because before I could react the can had hit the floor and the top had sprung off. Oily, white sludge started creeping out in all directions and I could feel the smell beginning to clog my nose. I wasn't sure what to do until Mom walked in and helped me clean it up. She gave me a lesson about cleaning up your messes quickly so they don't become a bigger deal. Why doesn't everyone know that? It seems like we don't even care about all the damage we're causing. Like we think it's somebody else's mess.

On Wednesday I was telling my friend about something when the teacher asked if anybody had parents or friends that worked at the power plant nearby. I raised my hand and so did about half of the class. It felt nice to know that I wasn't alone until she told us that our parents are partly responsible for a large part of climate change. The whole class got really quiet after she said that. She wasn't trying to make us feel bad or anything, but she sure did. I think she realized her mistake because she quickly went back to discussing the science and the history.

I don't think she's wrong to blame our parents but I don't think it's fair either. I know that my dad didn't really have a choice to work anywhere else. And Mom says we donate to climate change organizations around Christmas time. After that class I went home and told Mom and Dad about what my teacher said, how Dad was responsible for rising sea levels and global warming. I thought he might get defensive or look guilty but instead he just smiled and sighed. He said there's a lot of different things that go into the climate crisis and many of them are well out of his control. He said without this job we wouldn't have all the things we enjoy, like ice cream or Mario Kart. He had to make a decision for his family and sometimes the best decisions have bad parts too. I'm not sure what I would choose in that situation; it seems like a hard choice for anyone to make.

August 20, 2030

To be an environmentalist, as I see it, is to fight for the truest good of them all. There can be no greater battle than the one to protect your home and your family. Everything we know and love, even those we have not yet known to love, is at stake here. There is no fight more encompassing, no fight with greater stakes, and no fight more worthy. It requires a certain level of selflessness too, going to battle for a future you may not live to see.

At least that's what one professor told us before I dropped the class. That was freshman year I think. I wasn't really interested in the class and I wanted to make space for my economics gen ed requirements so I left after that first lecture. But lately, in lieu of recent events, I've been thinking a lot about that first, and only, meeting. I don't really recall much about the topic of the class, given that it was a few years ago and I only stayed for 50 minutes, but I do remember the professor. He was this sort of eccentric, energetic guy, full of life and vibrancy, running all over the stage, even when just going over the syllabus. His long red scarf would trail behind him in a strange but beautiful dance and he would have to push it out of the way if he turned too abruptly. Sometimes he would forget and receive a face full of red wool. I kind of enjoyed his little performance to be honest.

Anyway I'm getting distracted. What sticks in my head after all these years is what he said just as the class was wrapping up.

We can afford to make mistakes but we cannot afford to ignore them.

Something about this is stuck in my head now. Something about the brief pause after he said it that meant more than the actual words.

At the time I barely even flinched. Along with the rest of the class I bolted out the door the first chance I got, too preoccupied to give it any thought. And yet, his words still ring in my ears. Something about the undeniable truth coupled with his understanding gaze. Almost like a loving parent scolding their child.

I think, in part, this phrase has resurfaced because there seems to be an awful lot of mistakes happening and equal amounts of ignoring. Every morning the news is flooded with terrible stories of famine, disease, fire, hurricanes, and more. The world, they say, is heating up and it's not slowing down. We're too late, they cry. There's not enough time. Rising sea levels have crushed coastal communities, more and more species go extinct every day, and it seems like each day is hotter than the last. But at the same time nothing is happening. No new policies are introduced, no new rules or laws. Nothing is happening to make the bad things end and the good things start.

Back when I decided to pursue economics I knew of the climate crisis, of its impacts, its causes and who was responsible. But I didn't know it would be this bad. I choose a path to provide for my family and for myself. Economics seemed like the surest path towards that goal, the one with the straightest road away from the past. I knew if I worked hard enough I could find a job, send money back home, and indulge in the delights I had so often missed out on. In short, I chose economics

because it seemed the easiest way toward self-preservation. I was following Dad's advice, putting the happiness and care of my family before anything else. Even though I knew I was ignoring the environment, I felt like I had no choice. Like he used to say, sometimes the best choices have bad parts too.

April 6. 2034

Mom called a few days ago. The first time in a few months. She said Dad was in the hospital because he had been coughing a lot and was easily fatigued. He's probably fine, she told me, but I could tell she was scared from the long pauses on the other end. For a long time she had wanted him to see a doctor, mostly because he was always complaining about some ailment or the other. Once he hurt his foot so badly that he had to call a taxi to drive him home from work but he still refused to see a doctor about it. Mom got really mad after that, yelling and shouting about how he had more responsibility now, how he has to set a good example for us kids. After that he started going more often. I think he realized how important it was for him to be healthy for the family.

I finally got to speak on the phone with him yesterday. When he answered I could hear the change in his voice. It was no longer smooth and baritonal like I remember it from my childhood. More like a truck driving over a gravelly road. We talked for a while about how Mom was doing and how he didn't like being sidelined for so long.

I feel like I've let her down, he eventually disclosed to me, if I can't provide for my family, who am I?

He was quiet for a long time after that. I tried to get him to talk by telling him about my work and the things I was up to but I could tell he wasn't really paying attention. For him, working for his family, being the one to support us, is everything. Remnants of a different time I suppose. Ever since I can remember he has always been the breadwinner. Mom had a job, yes, but she was always the one taking days off when we were sick or had no school. Dad was the one working long hours, taking extra shifts so we could live our lives. Often, in the months and weeks before Christmas, Dad would work weekends to earn some extra money for the holidays. Now, sidelined by his injury, I could tell his pride was hurt. His sense of identity was lost.

Before I hung up, gathering that he would rather I didn't see him wallowing in his self-pity, I told him, and Mom who was listening, that I would cover the hospital bill and any other expenses they needed for the time being. I had saved up quite a bit and my economics education certainly didn't hurt. It's my time to step up, I told Dad, you can rest now. This is why I chose a career in economics after all. For moments like this, to provide when he couldn't anymore.

Mom was very grateful and said she'd talk to me later when they had more information. Dad, as expected, was quiet.

July 2, 2034

There is a certain way we tell someone something they don't want to hear. A specific look, a turn of phrase, a pause even, are all left as clues that point to a barely concealed truth. There is a profound kindness in this act, and a deep sadness too. It requires an understanding of what the words will mean and the grace to bestow upon them the gift of self-discovery. If done correctly, the truth is placed gently by their feet, one last gift, one last freedom, before reality becomes forever suffocating. It's what that professor was trying to tell us back in freshman year. It is what my mother told me when Dad was first admitted to the hospital. And it is what the doctors told Mom when they discovered the cancer in my father's lungs.

Mom could barely breathe through her sobs when she told me. It's not fair, she kept saying. It's not fair. Not only that but Dad's company, NEXO, won't even cover the bill, saying he's been out of work for too long. He has cancer, of course he's been out, I told his manager. How can he work if he's sick? They wouldn't listen. He's worked for them for 30 years. Unbelievable.

I made plans with Mom to come home in a few weeks, when I can get time off from work. My brother was already there taking care of both of them so there wasn't any rush, she said. A few weeks, I told her, in the meantime let me know when you need anything, anything at all.

When I got off the phone I just sat in the silence for a while.

Cancer.

Cancer, for goodness sakes.

Just writing the word is painful enough.

They hadn't told me the cause but it wasn't hard to deduce. 30 years in a power plant can't be good for any part of your body. Not to mention the fact that we lived within 3 miles of the place. Put it all together, the late nights, the early mornings, the weekends, and you could have almost predicted it. Not that you would want to, of course. But you could.

I had always rested against the idea that money, hard work, and persistence could always address the problems I needed it to. It's why I made that career choice so many years ago. Ever since I realized that Dad couldn't work forever I had made it my mission to be there when he faltered. To step up and provide for my family like he had done for so long. But now that time had come and I was unable to do anything. I could only send so much money, pay for so many tests. I was stuck, like all those years ago, watching Dad fight against something I could do nothing about.

December 14, 2034

Dad died yesterday, late in the night after everyone went to sleep, the doctors said. Typical I suppose, waiting until no one could stop him. One last way to claim his self-sufficiency. Mom was in tears before they even told her. As much as we all knew it was coming it hurt just the same. I had come home on the weekend before, half expecting to meet a funeral gathering when I arrived but Dad was kind enough to give me a few days to process the situation, a few more goodbyes, and a few more thank yous.

Afterwards Mom, my brother and I drove home, a broken silence drowning a broken family. We didn't know what to do when we got home so we just sat around the dining table in silence. What are you supposed to do after something like that? What do you do when there's nothing you can do? When someone is just missing. Gone.

I sat there, thinking about how odd everything looked and yet I knew it was the same as before. The same home he used to live in. The same house he would fill with his odor. The same door he would close. The same people still waiting for him to come home. It is strange how one can come to miss the smell of gasoline.

I've included a piece of his obituary so you may, in part, come to know the kind of man he was. I've removed his name out of respect, of course. We can only give so much after we have gone.

> [**REDACTED**], 57, died peacefully last night on June 19, 2035 at 11:37pm inside [**REDACTED**] Hospital. Born and raised in our community, he was a devoted husband, a loving father to his two sons, and a cherished friend to many. Those who had the privilege to know [**REDACTED**] will remember his unwavering dedication, hard work, and integrity. There was so little that could stand in his way when he knew what he wanted and so little that could pull him away when he was engaged. For 30 years [**REDACTED**] was a dedicated member of NEXO working his way from maintenance technician to sector supervisor through diligence and determination. His leadership and impact left a lasting impression on the entire community and his unwavering energy inspired all of us to continue pursuing our dreams. But more than his work or accomplishments, it was his kindness, generosity and steadfast dedication to those he loved that defined him. If there was ever a figure to epitomize the spirit of this community, he was it. He exemplified the values and commitment of our community in every moment of his life. His loyalty to his family and community was never questioned. May his love and care for us never diminish and his legacy never die out.

May 31, 2036

I've been thinking a lot about Dad's passing recently. There's something ominous about how it all came together. How it seems almost inevitable when you take everything into account; the long hours at the plant, the constant smell of gas, his staggered breathing near the end. How, even though he had every chance to find a way out, he stayed. He stayed and he paid the price for it.

Dad had always said he made the best decision for his family and that sometimes the best decisions have unfortunate consequences. Terrible consequences even. But I'm beginning to think he was never given the chance to make that decision. That maybe it was thrust upon him by virtue of his birthplace. When you examine the trajectory of his life it seems destined for that miserable fate.

But how can that be? How can a species, predicated on the miracle of free will, in a country built on the idea of rags to riches, give birth to an individual whose fate is determined before he is born? How can he be given a life sentence before his life had even begun? There is something deeply wrong about that. Something horrendously unjust.

June 2, 2036

I can't shake the idea of Dad's predestined fate. I did some digging on the location of power plants in the country and their proximity to communities like ours. The results are shocking.

Oxnard, CA

Palo Verde, AZ

Bay City, TX

Colstrip, MT

Baldwin, IL

The list goes on. All of these, and more, are towns located precariously close to major power plants. And all of these, and more, are home to increased rates of cancer and adverse health effects. That seems too perfect to be coincidental. Like maybe there is a greater story at play.

During my search I came across two terms, environmental injustice and environmental racism, which seem to perfectly encapsulate the situation I have been so astounded by. For decades, centuries even, waste sites and power generators have almost exclusively been placed alongside marginalized or impoverished communities. They are placed there with full knowledge of their consequences, of the devastation they inflict upon all those within range. Wealthy communities, primarily white in this country, have the power and privilege to refuse this proximity, advocating, as they should I suppose, for its placement elsewhere. As a result, the generator or power plant or nuclear waste site gets put awfully close to communities without the resources to advocate for themselves. They become the victims of their own _____.

But it goes deeper than that. Those people, the ones lacking in power and privilege, were never given a fair voice in the argument. They were ignored, as they always have been, because they were never going to be heard. They were, we were, knocked down before we could start and then told to get up twice as fast. This, I'm beginning to understand, is the underlying injustice of my generation, of my father's death.

To determine the fate of your own citizens while simultaneously preaching the ideal of the "American Dream", a dream that was never afforded to millions of people, is hypocrisy at its greatest peak. This dream, of upward mobility through hard work and dedication, is just that, a dream. A dream that dissolves the moment you wake up to reality. A dream to keep us quiet, sleeping even, while the injustice rages on. It is an illusion, forced upon us to keep us slaving away in the boiler room of the country; a disgusting and discriminatory illusion.

July 17, 2037

We are the harbingers of a time to come. A revolution long overdue. The products of the seeds you have sown. Did you know what you were planting? What anger you have cultivated? What despair? It is time you find out.

We are the forgotten, the disparaged, the ignored. We are the downtrodden, the fallen, the wounded. The ones you left amongst the rubble of your failures, the scavengers and the refuse to your golden age. We are the workers, the slaves to your machine. Those whose sweat fills your pockets, whose tears you wear proudly around your neck, and whose blood fills the walls of your homes. We are the victims of all injustices; environmental, racial, restorative, indigenous, climate, gender, ecological and all those you know but fear to acknowledge.

You have dismissed us without care or mercy. Another footnote to the great epic of history. You have silenced and suffocated us with your false promises and idle discussions. You have slaughtered us to fuel your fantasies, to construct your merest whim. You have told us to wait, to be patient, for good things come to those who wait.

But we will wait no longer. A new chapter will be written. The injustice of our lives, the injustice of the system you have created, can no longer stand. It must be eradicated, and with it the ugly face of dishonest progress. We act on behalf of the environment, on behalf of its torture, its catastrophe, its crisis. The ecological crisis cannot go on. We represent those who can no longer speak. We stand against cruelty and discrimination. We are the global south, the slums, the poor, the wounded, the shunned, the marginalized, the oppressed, and all those unjustly treated. We declare rebellion against the world you have created and the corruption you breed. We are the rising, the weeds to your Garden of Eden, the unrelenting, eager to dismantle that which so often trampled us. We are the broke but not the broken. We have been worn thin, but not out. We call out to all those like us. Join us. Join us in the creation of a new garden, one that values the interests of all its parts equally. A system that allows the small to be heard and forces the mighty to listen. The fight has just begun, but the war was started long ago. We will not be quiet any longer. We demand to be heard. To be included. We will be remembered. We are the dreamers, the believers, the determined, the ones who will bring the change.

We are together. And we will fight.

We are **The People's Voice.**

We will be heard.

Editor's Note – This is the introduction to the rough draft of The People's Demands*, a manifesto and declaration of rebellion produced by The People's Voice- the organization started by our author to rebel against injustice around the world. The final product was distributed around the globe, sparking the*

flames of uprising that have led to our world today. We have included this segment as a reflection of the anger, determination, and drive during the time of its creation. It is not an example of proper disobedience. We do not condone or endorse the illegal actions taken by the organization or any of the violent events that resulted. This collection is not intended to facilitate future uprisings, nor do we wish to promote violence.

March 20, 2044

It is a strange thing to see your dreams become reality. To observe the construction of a world you were told was impossible. For seven years we fought for the chance to be where we are today. We kicked, scratched, and pulled ourselves out of the depths plunged by our ancestors, arriving, at last, to a world as free as we could make it.

And yet, ever since that glorious victory back in November of last year, the March of the Masses I hear they are calling it, it has become apparent the inadequacy of our preparations. We were victorious, yes, our voices were always going to be heard, but now, tasked with the responsibility of adjudicating a fair and just world, the task appears incredibly daunting.

While the movement was still gaining traction it was easy to procure a list of demands, guidelines for the world we hope to enact. We sat in those greasy beanbag chairs of the basement, freely brainstorming the ideals of a country we hoped to inherit. But those were the idle talks of dissatisfaction. Did we truly believe in the imminent victory we so adamantly demanded? I cannot say for certain.

But we did win, and with great gusto, I might add. The raising of the lower and middle classes against the elite proved far easier than perhaps anyone had expected. The frustration of a thousand generations was, as we had theorized, pressurized and eager to explode upon the first spark of rebellion. There was music and dancing and celebration on the lawns of power. Raucous festivals, commemorating the trails worn before us, honoring those who blazed the paths toward our undeniable victory. Our march across the country, always gathering momentum, culminated in the largest campout in world history, a massive celebration of the once forgotten as we demanded our acknowledgement. It was truly a joyous occasion.

And now we are here. In full voice, with millions awaiting the spoils of their victory. I have spoken at length with the President and the two chambers of Congress; we did not wish to uproot the foundation of this nation, only to disrupt its footing and watch the corrupt topple from their pearly spires. Many of the talks have been incredibly fruitful with discussions of progressive legislation that returns power and wealth to the masses. We have already dismantled the large conglomerates, dispersing their market shares into the hands of local businesses. Clean energy, through solar, wind, water and nuclear, is currently in progress all across the country, largely funded by the remains of the fossil fuel industry. In a sweeping motion we banned the continued drilling for oil, offering incentives for investment in green energy and rewarding those already in full effect.

And, most importantly, we reexamined the injustices that brought us here, enacting laws and amendments to prevent the resurgence of such discrimination. There are promising talks on the rights of nature, of increased education and basic rights, of the long overdue abolition of racial prejudice in the courts, of a cap and trade system for the few remaining polluters, and of introducing fair

representation in the Chambers. Demilitarization was introduced almost immediately, the withdrawn funds used to support those encumbered by the various transitions we required.

But there is still more to do. There is always more to do it seems. Change, as it turns out, is never easy or brisk.

Feb 2, 2046

During one particularly languid afternoon at the Capital, a representative and I discovered a mutual appreciation for a video game I had long forgotten – my beloved MarioKart. We quickly found ourselves battling in the middle of the House, intently focused on the small screen resting upon the podium. As we raced around the tightly wound tracks, jostling playfully for position, it dawned on me the true reason underlying my adoration for this game.

I should start by saying I have loved MarioKart wholeheartedly ever since that quiet Christmas morning when Dad presented me with one last gift. The following weeks were a blur of checkered flags and burning rubber; from sunup to sundown my fingers twitched at the controls, desperate to squeeze every ounce of speed possible from my pixelated vehicle. I was deeply, irretrievably in love, without pausing to understand the true reason why.

For those who might not be familiar, MarioKart is a racing game where you can race as one of over 40 artfully designed characters. I'd recommend Baby Luigi, my personal favorite, but each of the characters have their own strengths and weaknesses. Once you select a character you can customize your vehicle, wheels, and emergency glider before heading out to battle against 11 competitors on one of the numerous, winding tracks. The game then becomes very simple- be the first to cross the finish line after three laps. Except for one complication.

Dotted around the track are items boxes, spinning prisms of color that, if driven through, bestow upon their destroyer a coveted power-up. Banana peels to throw on the track, kart-honing red shells, a speed boosting mushroom and a lightning bolt that shrinks all of your competitors are all possible gifts one might receive. As you might suspect, these items cause immense chaos throughout the race and their effective use is essential to any serious competitor. But what makes this feature so compelling is how the game determines which power-up you get.

First place, for example, is more likely to get a defense or passive item like a banana peel or coin. Conversely, racers in 9th to 12th place have the chance to receive powerful items like an everlasting golden mushroom, lightning bolt, or even Bullet Bill, a token that temporarily transforms your kart into a bullet with exceptional cornering and inevitably takes you away from the doldrums of last place. In other words, the farther back you are, the better items you get. If you are left behind, it is never for long.

It struck me then, racing furiously in the halls of government, that MarioKart is the epitome of an equitable society. It has created a world in which every player, regardless of their position upon entering the final lap, has a chance to cross the finish line first. We might not all have the same chance at getting a Bullet Bill but we don't all need a Bullet Bill. The aide we receive is reflective of our privilege and our circumstance. Our chance at victory is always equal. That is the world I want to live in.

December 17, 2050

The crown of power weighs heavy on the head of the worthy. Or so I'm told. I have never harbored any wish to grasp the strings of influence and even now, having only briefly tasted its intoxicating breath, I feel my spirit waning.

Over these last few years I have scorned the temptress of power, thwarted her advances and denied her every inclination. I have, for better or worse, ardently avoided the limelight, seeking instead to promote the collective power we fought so hard for all those years ago.

But there is one project to which I succumbed to her advances. Back home, in that dusty gray community where childhood still lives, I took it upon myself to oversee the demolition of the old NEXO building. It had been out of commission for years now, but even so, the faint hint of gasoline could be detected when you walked by. The memories of its suffocating smoke plumes, the long days in its shadow, the hours spent wishing it would crumble all flooded back when I first came upon that flimsy, rusted fence. Those tall smokestacks, reaching high up into the sky, still evoked that same sensation of fear and disgust, almost as if plumes of gas were still rising from the depths of the past and into my nose. The cracked concrete facade still held within it an air of intimidation, of dread, and of sacrifice. It had to go.

At first, some members of the community wanted it to remain. It is a symbol of how far we've come, they said, its abandonment is a symbol of how far we've come. For so long the plant had employed the men and women of our town, giving them jobs when no one else would. It is the reason for so much of our lives, they argued, we would be lost without it. I tended to agree with them on that point, having owed it my love for MarioKart and thus my equitable ambitions. But at the same time, its continued existence was a plague in the minds of those who had suffered at its grasp. The trauma incurred by its plumes, the friends and family lost to its poison; there was no way we could let it continue to tower over us. It had already consumed so much of our lives.

Once the deal was finalized the whole town came out to watch its destruction. Kids, parents, and grandparents alike all gathered to watch its obliteration. This building, this monstrosity, was finally being laid to rest. Music echoed off its stone walls as dancing and celebration roared below. Sounds of laughter and joy and love rang out in the air, the symphony of a community finally getting its long overdue justice. It was the largest festival in living memory.

When the time came to light the fuse, a hush swept over the congregation. For a brief, anticipatory moment we held our breath, staring, for the last time, at the walls of cruelty we thought would never fall, transported to a place of deep sorrow where the light of tomorrow will never reach, waiting for a moment we feared would never come.

And then it was done. The children pressed down the detonator and with a few loud bangs the power plant succumbed to our might, folding inward as if eating itself from within. We breathed, for the first time in a long time, a fresh breath of air.

We can't build anything on its grave just yet, on account of the poisoned soil and all, but we're letting nature run its course in the hopes that someday a school might be built. It's quite a lovely thought I think, to imagine future generations learning the history of a corrupt society they now stand upon, walking the hallways of their ancestors. Rather poetic.

Today, I walked past the empty field on my lunch break, taking in the fresh air amidst the birdsong of freedom. I try to imagine what Dad might think of the place, whether or not he might miss it with some sort of dark irony. He had spent so many hours within that living tomb after all, so many days and weeks and months trapped within its grasp. So much of his life was held within its walls, so many breaths. For a long time after he passed I was too scared to return home, using my work as an excuse to avoid confronting his absence and to avoid standing in the shadows of his killer. But now, that clear sky where it once stood is far more comforting than any hug or embrace. Revenge, it turns out, tastes sweetest in the mouth of those deserving.

I've decided to stop writing for a while. To live in the present rather than dictating the past. I'm thinking I might turn this over to an editor friend of mine, see if he might have a use for these musings. Maybe these entries can tell the tales of a time long gone. Maybe they can provide a glimpse into the past, details of the lives of those most affected by the circumstances of their time. Perhaps that's what Mom meant so many years ago when she gifted me this journal. To tell the stories of injustice. My story of injustice.

Editor's Note– This is the last recorded entry found within the journal. The author requested that this collection be published after his death to permit a level of privacy and authenticity to its publication. Our author died on March 17, 2103, surrounded by his family and loved ones. The cause of death has not been disclosed. If you wish to pay your respects, you may do so by writing to the publisher who, if inclined, will divulge the address of the fallen power plant, the last discerning vestige of his work.

Sources:

1. February 25, 2025 Lecture on Environmental Justice/Injustice
2. Map of power plants and nearby communities in the US https://synapse.maps.arcgis.com/apps/dashboards/201fc98c0d74482d8b3acb0c4cc47f16